add religion to terrorism' (Focus Group, Private University[7]). While the majority of participants believed terrorism to be one of the main problems facing Pakistan, the role of hostile countries, whether India and its intelligence service RAW,[8] even Israel and its intelligence service Mossad, along with the United States are held responsible for terror in Pakistan. '*But Taliban is a label to terrorize and manipulate you. ISIS, TTP titles created by media. The super power US is behind these titles. To create a sense of terrorising*' (Focus Group, Government University[9]). Respondents in this research constantly challenged the identity of the Taliban. '*But the people who join the Taliban came to Pakistan but not real Pakistanis. They are primarily from Afghanistan who settled in Pakistan. They do the dirty work but the people behind them are foreigners. You can see from the videos that are circulated all over the net. The Taliban is more white, definitely from the North or Afghanistan*' (Focus Group, Private University[10]). Young people were of course right that foreigners are involved, as Uzbek, Turkmen and Saudi fighters from the Afghan wars have joined the fight in Pakistan. However, the idea that fellow Muslims could unleash terror in the 'Islamic Republic' of Pakistan seemed unbelievable for many of the participants in this study. '*No Muslim would do this to other Muslims*' is a refrain heard often during the research over the years across all types of respondents. Nevertheless, as the extract from a focus group discussion below shows, there were other points of view: for some, groups such as the Taliban are 'tools' working for whoever pays them the most money, while for others they were following a misinterpretation of Islam, a misinterpretation propagated by Saudi Arabia, another country that was seen by some (mostly a minority) to be behind their existence in Pakistan and Afghanistan. '*I know this is a stretch and might sound silly but at one point there were rumours that the beggars on the streets were collecting money for the Taliban*' (People start laughing); '*I heard that the Indian advisor to Modi mention how it is about money, whoever offers more money to the Taliban*'; *Q.: But what about the Salafi ideology?* '*I think the ideology is to fool people. They work for whoever pays them*' (Focus Group, Private University[11]).

These theories of foreign forces are reinforced through media, by popular political analysts and political show hosts, whose references participants shared in their discussion on terrorism in Pakistan.[12]

The extent of the violence unleashed by different terrorist groups was captured by Ishrat Hussain (2018) in his analysis of terrorism in Pakistan that highlights how 'a variety of perpetrators – including the TTP, other Al-Qaeda-inspired groups, sectarian militants, and nationalist insurgents in